



Campfire

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Program Goals and Objectives

The primary goal of the "Campfire" application is to help new university students easily find study partners and interest-based groups during their first weeks at university.

Many new students arrive at university without knowing their classmates, campus communities, or available student groups. This can make it difficult for them to find people with similar academic goals, hobbies, languages, or study habits. Campfire aims to solve this problem by providing a simple and friendly mobile interface where students can discover groups, match with study partners, and communicate with other students in a safe and organised way.

To achieve this goal, the application must perform two main tasks: recommend compatible study partners based on shared academic and personal interests, and help students discover and join relevant interest groups.

Based on the goal and objectives listed above, the program shall fulfil the following functional requirements:

- Allow new students to create a profile by entering their name, faculty or major, year of study, interests, and preferred study style.
- Suggest study partners based on shared courses, common interests, study availability, and compatibility percentage.
- Display recommended interest groups based on the student's profile and selected interests.
- Allow users to search and filter groups by faculty, interest, schedule, and group size.
- Show detailed group information, including description, tags, members, meeting time, and location.
- Allow users to join a group, save a group, skip a recommendation, or connect with a suggested study partner.
- Provide a messaging section for direct messages and group communication.
- Display notifications and unread message indicators clearly.
- Provide safety features such as the ability to report inappropriate behaviour or leave a group.

The application must not only connect students but also be simple, trustworthy, and easy to use. Since the main users are new students, the interface should avoid unnecessary complexity and help users understand what to do without needing instructions. Therefore, the following additional usability objectives were defined:

1. Provide a short onboarding process that collects only necessary information.
2. Use clear labels, familiar icons, and simple navigation.

3. Present groups and study partner suggestions in card format to make information easy to scan.
4. Show match percentages and shared interests clearly so users understand why a recommendation appears.
5. Reduce the number of steps needed to find and contact a study partner or group.
6. Use a warm and clean visual style to make the application feel friendly and trustworthy.
7. Ensure that the user can browse, save, join, skip, and message without confusion.
8. Test whether the application meets the expectations of first-year and new university students.

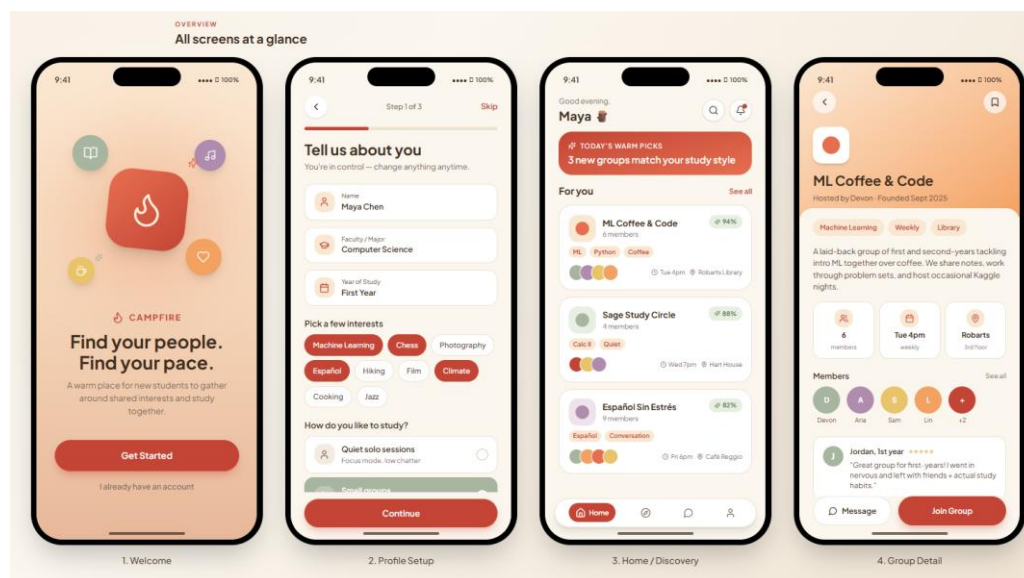


Figure 1. Campfire Application – Overview of Main Screens

Figure 1 presents an overview of the Campfire application screens. The Welcome screen introduces the application with the tagline "Find your people. Find your pace." The Profile Setup screen collects the basic information needed for personalized recommendations, including faculty, year of study, interests, and preferred study style. The Home screen displays personalized group suggestions with match percentages, while the Group Detail screen provides full information about a selected group before the user decides to join.

1 User Analysis

To determine the demand for a student connection application and identify the most useful functions, three university students with different academic backgrounds and years of study were interviewed. The survey was conducted using a structured interview method with predefined questions. The results were subsequently compiled into individual user profiles.

The purpose of the survey was to understand whether students experience difficulties finding study partners or interest groups, what methods or tools they currently use, and what features they would expect from an application such as Campfire.

Survey Questionnaire: Person 1

Question	Answer
Age	22
Gender	Female
Education	Final-year undergraduate student, Business
Do you find it difficult to meet people with similar academic interests at university?	Yes, especially during the Erasmus exchange period. Being in a new environment made it significantly harder to find people with similar academic interests or to form a consistent study group. The social and academic networks that most students build over time simply did not exist for me at that stage.
Have you ever used any app to find study partners or join groups?	No. I was not aware that applications specifically designed for finding study partners or student groups existed. I assumed finding study groups was something that happened naturally through university channels.
What features should such an app have? Why?	The application should be easy to use and straightforward to navigate. It should offer a variety of study-related options and, most importantly, provide a reliable way to find a compatible study group based on shared subjects and availability.
Is the visual appearance of the app important to you? Why?	Yes, a clean and organised interface matters. If the application is visually cluttered or difficult to understand, it reduces trust and makes it harder to use effectively.

Survey Questionnaire: Person 2

Question	Answer
Age	23
Gender	Male

Education	Third-year undergraduate student, Teaching
Do you find it difficult to meet people with similar academic interests at university?	Not entirely. I can sometimes find study groups, but the main challenge is that schedules vary considerably from one student to another. Even when there is mutual interest in studying together, finding a time that works for everyone often becomes an obstacle.
Have you ever used any app to find study partners or join groups?	No, I have not used any similar applications before. Finding study groups has been a mostly informal process, relying on personal contacts or class announcements.
What features should such an app have? Why?	The most important feature would be the ability to communicate with potential study partners before committing to a session, in order to assess compatibility. Beyond that, the ability to find a suitable study group based on subject and schedule alignment would be highly valuable.
Is the visual appearance of the app important to you? Why?	It matters to a reasonable extent. The interface should be clear and easy to navigate so that finding the right group or person does not require unnecessary effort.

Survey Questionnaire: Person 3

Question	Answer
Age	23
Gender	Female
Education	Final-year undergraduate student, Teaching
Do you find it difficult to meet people with similar academic interests at university?	Yes, to a considerable extent. Study groups are occasionally formed on campus, but this is not consistent and tends to depend heavily on proximity and chance rather than shared academic goals or preferences.
Have you ever used any app to find study partners or join groups?	No. My approach has been limited to searching within the university environment itself, relying on physical presence on campus to connect with other students. I was not aware of any dedicated application for this purpose.
What features should such an app have? Why?	An easy and reliable way to find study groups would be the core feature. Additionally, the ability to discover new study locations would be a welcome addition, as studying in different environments can help with focus and motivation. It would also be important to be able to message and coordinate with the group in advance so that sessions are well-organised before they begin.

Is the visual appearance of the app important to you? Why?

Yes, very much so. The application needs to be visually attractive and intuitive. If it is confusing or unappealing, I would be unlikely to continue using it over time. Good design directly affects how comfortable and confident I feel using the app.

Based on the survey results, the target users of Campfire are primarily students in their final or middle years of study, including those participating in exchange programmes such as Erasmus, who face structural or situational barriers to forming study groups. A recurring theme across all three interviews was the absence of a dedicated, student-specific tool for this purpose, none of the respondents had previously used a similar application.

The interviews consistently highlighted the following user needs: an intuitive and accessible interface, the ability to discover and filter study groups by subject and availability, communication features that allow coordination before a study session, and a visually appealing design that encourages continued use. These findings directly informed the functional requirements and usability objectives of the Campfire application.

2 Competitor Analysis

One of the key steps in developing the Campfire application is competitor analysis. In this stage, three existing platforms commonly used for finding groups, communities, or new people were analysed. The selected competitors are Meetup, Discord, and Bumble BFF.

These platforms were selected because they offer functions related to group discovery, messaging, or social connection. However, none of them is designed specifically for new university students who want to find study partners and academic communities.

Meetup

Meetup is a platform that helps users find local groups, events, and activities based on shared interests. Users can search for events, join groups, and meet people who share similar hobbies or goals. At first glance it is useful because it already focuses on interest-based communities; however, the platform is too general for the specific needs of new university students, as most events are aimed at adults, professionals, or public social activities rather than academic study groups.

Weaknesses of Meetup:

- **Not student-specific:** The platform is not designed around university life, faculties, courses, or academic needs.
- **No study partner matching:** Users can find events, but they cannot search for a partner based on shared courses or study habits.

- **Too broad:** The volume of unrelated content makes it difficult for students to find relevant academic groups.
- **Formal tone:** The platform feels more appropriate for professional networking than for first-year university students.
- **Limited academic filtering:** There is no direct filter for faculty, course, year of study, or study schedule.

Discord

Discord is a communication platform where users can join or create communities organised into servers and channels, supporting text, voice, and video communication. Many students use Discord for faculty groups or course discussions. While it is strong for real-time communication after a student has joined a server, it is not designed as a discovery or matching platform. New students often require an invitation link to join and may find large servers overwhelming due to numerous channels and unorganised conversations.

Weaknesses of Discord:

- **No onboarding for student matching:** Users are not guided through any process based on faculty, courses, or study preferences.
- **Difficult discovery:** New students must already know which server to join or receive an invitation link.
- **Overwhelming interface:** The volume of channels and notifications can confuse users who are new to the platform.
- **No compatibility system:** Discord does not suggest study partners based on shared courses, availability, or interests.
- **Limited group discovery:** The platform is better suited for communication within an existing group than for finding one.

Bumble BFF

Bumble BFF is a feature within the Bumble application designed to help users form new friendships through a swipe-based matching system. Its interaction model is familiar and clean. However, it is not designed for academic contexts and its matching system is entirely social, lacking course information, faculty filters, study schedules, or group-based learning features.

Weaknesses of Bumble BFF:

- **Not academic:** The platform is designed for social friendships, not study partnerships or student groups.
- **No course or faculty filters:** Users cannot match based on shared academic subjects or timetables.
- **No structured group discovery:** The focus is on one-to-one friendship rather than organised study communities.

- **Association with dating:** Because Bumble is primarily a dating platform, some students may feel uncomfortable using it in an academic context.
- **No study availability matching:** The platform does not account for when or how users prefer to study.

The competitor analysis confirms that existing platforms address parts of the problem but fall short of a complete solution for university students. Meetup is too broad and not academically oriented; Discord is effective for communication but poorly suited to discovery; and Bumble BFF offers a clean matching experience but is social rather than academic in focus. Campfire is designed to bridge this gap by combining interest-based group discovery, study partner matching, academic filters, and in-app messaging within a single student-centred interface.

3 Final Application Concept

The final Campfire application is designed as a student-centred platform that helps new university students build academic and social connections. The application is structured around a simple and progressive user journey:

- The student opens the application and is introduced through a welcoming onboarding screen.
- The student creates a profile by providing basic academic information and selecting personal interests.
- The application generates personalised group and study partner recommendations based on the profile.
- The student can explore, filter, save, join, or skip recommendations at their own pace.
- Once connected, the student communicates with groups or individuals through the in-app messaging system.

The prototype, developed in Figma, includes seven main screens covering the complete user journey: the Welcome screen, Profile Setup, Home / Discovery, Group Detail, Explore, Match & Connect, and Messages. Each screen was designed to support the core HCI principles of simplicity, learnability, user control, and reduced cognitive load.

The warm color palette, rounded card components, descriptive tags, and bottom navigation bar collectively creates an interface that feels approachable and easy to understand without prior instruction. The inclusion of match percentages, shared course indicators, and study style preferences ensures that recommendations are transparent and relevant, which builds user trust and encourages continued engagement.

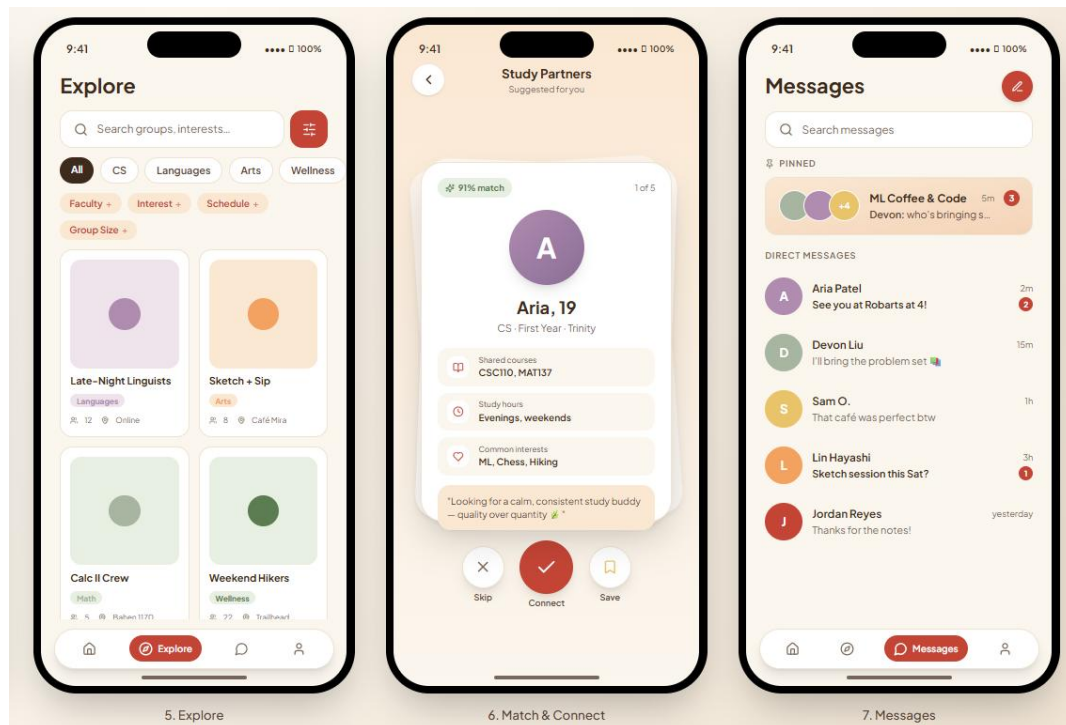


Figure 2. Campfire Application – Explore, Match & Connect, and Messages Screens

Figure 2 illustrates the secondary screens of the application. The Explore screen provides comprehensive search and filtering tools, allowing students to browse groups by interest, faculty, schedule, and group size. The Match & Connect screen presents individual study partner suggestions alongside a compatibility percentage, shared courses, available study hours, and common interests. The Messages screen organises both group chats and direct messages in a clean inbox layout, enabling students to coordinate study sessions before they take place.

Conclusion

The Campfire application addresses a genuine and underserved need among university students: the difficulty of finding compatible study partners and academic communities, particularly during the early stages of university life or while participating in exchange programmes.

The user analysis revealed that none of the interviewed students had previously used a dedicated application for this purpose, and all identified the same core needs: an intuitive interface, subject and schedule-based filtering, pre-session communication, and a visually appealing design that encourages long-term use.

The competitor analysis demonstrated that while platforms such as Meetup, Discord, and Bumble BFF each offer relevant features, none provides a complete or student-specific solution. Campfire is designed to fill this gap by bringing together group discovery, study

partner matching, academic filtering, and messaging within a single, cohesive mobile application.

The final goal of Campfire extends beyond simple connection: it aims to help students feel more included, supported, and confident in their academic environment, regardless of whether they are in their first semester or their final year.